



Generic Classes and Methods

Java How to Program, 9/e



Objectives

- ▶ What are generics methods and generic classes
- ▶ Use generic methods and classes



21.1 Introduction

- ▶ **Generic methods** and **generic classes** (and interfaces) enable you to specify, with a single method declaration, a set of related methods, or with a single class declaration, a set of related types, respectively.
- ▶ Generics also provide compile-time type safety that allows you to catch invalid types at compile time.



21.2 Motivation for Generic Methods

- ▶ Overloaded methods are often used to perform similar operations on different types of data.
- ▶ Study each `printArray` method.
 - Note that the type array element type appears in each method's header and `for`-statement header.
 - If we were to replace the element types in each method with a generic name—`T` by convention—then all three methods would look like the one in Fig. 21.2.



21.3 Generic Methods: Implementation and Compile-Time Translation

- ▶ If the operations performed by several overloaded methods are identical for each argument type, the overloaded methods can be more compactly and conveniently coded using a generic- method.
- ▶ You can write a single generic method declaration that can be called with arguments of different types.
- ▶ Based on the types of the arguments passed to the generic method, the compiler handles each method call appropriately.
- ▶ Line 22 begins method `printArray`'s declaration.



Code using Generics

- ▶ See code of print array using generics

21.4 Additional Compile-Time



Translation Issues: Methods That Use a Type Parameter as the Return Type

- ▶ Generic method `maximum` determines and return the largest of its three arguments of the same type.
- ▶ The relational operator `>` cannot be used with reference types, but it's possible to compare two objects of the same class if that class implements the generic **interface `Comparable<T>`**
- ▶ All the type-wrapper classes for primitive types implement this interface.
- ▶ Like generic classes, **generic interfaces** enable you to specify, with a single interface declaration, a set of related types.

21.4 Additional Compile-Time Translation



Issues: Methods That Use a Type Parameter as the Return Type (cont.)

- ▶ `Comparable<T>` objects have a `compareTo` method.
 - The method must return 0 if the objects are equal, a negative integer if `object1` is less than `object2` or a positive integer if `object1` is greater than `object2`.
- ▶ A benefit of implementing interface `Comparable<T>` is that `Comparable<T>` objects can be used with the sorting and searching methods of class `Collections` (package `java.util`).



See code

- ▶ See code of generic method maximum

21.4 Additional Compile-Time Translation



Issues: Methods That Use a Type Parameter as the Return Type (cont.)

- ▶ The type-parameter section specifies that `T` extends `Comparable<T>`—only objects of classes that implement interface `Comparable<T>` can be used with this method.
- ▶ `Comparable` is known as the **upper bound** of the type parameter.
- ▶ By default, `Object` is the upper bound.
- ▶ Type-parameter declarations that bound the parameter always use keyword **extends** regardless of whether the type parameter extends a class or implements an interface.
- ▶ The restriction of using `Comparable<T>` objects is important, because not all objects can be compared.

Additional Compile-Time Translation Issues: Methods That Use a Type Parameter as the Return Type



- ▶ `interface Comparable<T>`
- ▶ All the type-wrapper classes for primitive types implement this interface.
- ▶ Like generic classes, **generic interfaces** enable you to specify, with a single interface declaration, a set of related types.

2 Additional Compile-Time Translation Issues:

Methods That Use a Type Parameter as the Return Type (cont.)



- ▶ Type-parameter declarations that bound the parameter always use keyword **extends** regardless of whether the type parameter extends a class or implements an interface.
- ▶ The restriction of using **Comparable<T>** objects is important, because not all objects can be compared.



Basics of Generics

- ▶ Class definitions may include parameters for types
 - Called *generics*
- ▶ Programmer now can specify any class type for the type parameter
- ▶ View [class definition](#), listing 12.11
`class Sample<T>`
- ▶ Note use of `<T>` for the type parameter



Basics of Generics

- ▶ Legal to use parameter T almost anywhere you can use class type

- ▶ Example declaration

```
Sample <String> sample1 =  
    new Sample<String>();
```

- Cannot specify a primitive type for the type parameter

LISTING 12.11 A Class Definition That Uses a Type Parameter

```
public class Sample<T>
{
    private T data;

    public void setData(T newValue)
    {
        data = newValue;
    }

    public T getData()
    {
        return data;
    }
}
```

Check code





Generic Classes

- ▶ **LinkedList** is an example of a generic class that has this declaration

```
class LinkedList<E>
```

- ▶ Here, **E** specifies the type of objects that the list will hold.



Person List Example

- ▶ Check code